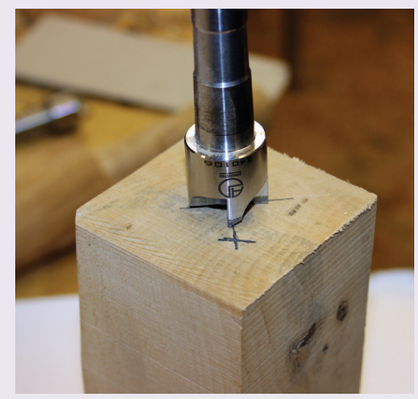
2-PRONG CENTRE

A 2-prong is also good for driving square timber, but more especially if the end of the timber is not square. If a 4-prong was used in this case, only one point may be driving the timber, meaning this could come loose when turning and may come off the lathe. This type is also good for turning natural-edge bowl blanks due to the radius on the bowl blank top. I tend to remove the bark where the prongs sit, so the prongs will go into the timber and give a better grip. Drive this in with the prongs running parallel to the grain on a bowl blank.

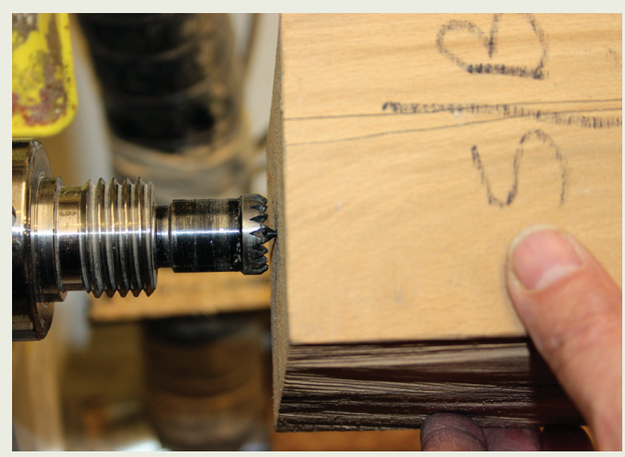
HOW TO USE

2- and 4-prong centres are driven into the timber with a mallet, never a hammer as this will damage the end of the Morse taper, which in turn will damage the shaft in the headstock. When mounting between centres just tighten the tailstock sufficiently to hold the centre in the timber. Over-tightening can damage the bearings in the headstock and the centre in the tailstock. You can also use a small saw to cut two diagonals lines for the prongs to sit in. This is not a method I use, but I know some people do this. Place a mark on the timber opposite a mark on one of the prongs; this means if you remove the item from between centres that you can replace this in exactly in the same position on the same prong.



STEB CENTRE

A steb centre is one I use a lot. I don't have to drive the centre in with a mallet due to this having a spring loaded point that retracts when I tighten the tailstock, engaging the teeth in the end of the timber. This type is not suitable for wet timber due to the small teeth, which don't grip very well in the wet fibres.



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